

struction sites is whether sustainability can lower costs and improve resilience or will it add another layer of expenditure.

Map this: Health Care Without Harm, along with consultancy Arup, estimates that healthcare accounts for nearly 4.4% of the world's greenhouse gas emissions. If it were a country, it would rank among the world's largest emitters. In India, the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) recorded 743 tonnes per day biomedical waste generation during the peak pandemic period.

THE BUSINESS CASE

For much of its history, sustainability in Indian healthcare revolved around biomedical waste rules, pollution board filings and accreditation requirements. Large hospital chains are now beginning to link sustainability directly with operating costs, hospital design and investor scrutiny.

"Sustainability is no longer viewed only as a compliance requirement but a strategic enabler that supports operational efficiency and long-term value creation," says Richa Singh Debgupta, Chief of Strategy and Group Head, ESG, Fortis Healthcare. Over the past three years, Fortis has achieved a 13% reduction in per occupied bed energy consumption. In FY26 alone, interventions cut per-bed Scope 1 and Scope 2 emissions by 8.7%, eliminating approximately 4,435 metric tonnes of CO₂. The group recycled more than 2.75 lakh kilolitres of treated wastewater and diverted over 104 metric tonnes of plastic waste from landfills by replacing conventional bags with compostable alternatives.

At Apollo Hospitals, India's largest private healthcare network with 74 hospitals and over 6,000 pharmacies, the sustainability roadmap is more structured. The

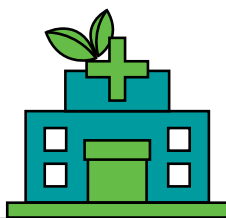
HEAL THE WORLD

India's hospital sector is becoming a major consumer of energy, water, chemicals, plastics and diagnostic materials, while generating large volumes of biomedical waste

As ESG disclosures become mainstream, hospital chains are facing growing pressure from regulators, investors, insurers and patients to improve sustainability practices

Large healthcare providers such as Apollo Hospitals Enterprise, Fortis Healthcare and Narayana Health are investing in renewable energy, wastewater recycling, biomedical waste segregation and digital monitoring systems to improve operational efficiency and reduce environmental impact

Biomedical waste management, energy consumption and water use are becoming central concerns



Apollo Sustainability Action Plan or ASAP ties sustainability oversight to board-level monitoring and links outcomes to 5% of hospital CEOs' performance evaluation. "Sustainability has moved from a peripheral obligation to a central pillar of Apollo's long-term business strategy," says Dr Preetha Reddy, Vice Chairperson, Apollo Hospitals.

Apollo's ESG Report FY2024 outlines the scale of these interventions. Project Virya, covering 40 hospitals and around 200 conservation projects, has generated energy cost savings of ₹297 crore over two years. A partnership with Smart Joules projects savings of 235 million kilowatt hours and ₹200 crore through 2030 without upfront capital investment by Apollo. The group recycled over 530,000 kilolitres water in FY2024 and recovered 4,800 metric tonnes general waste.

DESIGNED GREEN

New hospital projects are beginning to incorporate sustainability measures from the planning stage itself, even as older facilities continue retrofitting existing infrastructure. Decisions around hospital design, engineering systems and building certifications are being influenced by energy and resource efficiency considerations. "HVAC systems alone can account for 40-60% energy consumption in large tertiary-care hospitals," says Swami Nijamritananda Puri, Administrative Director of Amrita Hospital, Faridabad. "Operation theatres, ICUs and imaging systems are highly power intensive." The International Finance Corporation estimates that green hospitals can reduce energy and water consumption by 30% compared to conventionally designed facilities.

At Amrita Hospital, sustainability was built into the campus design, with sewage treatment plants,